

Vintage Wines, who quit his high-flying corporate job as a financial manager in CEAT Tyres five years ago to plunge into the wine business. With 1.10 lakh litres of wine ready in his boutique winery, Patil is on his way to realising his goal of "making premium Indian wine". In 2002, the B-school graduate headed to Niphad village in Nashik to pursue his dream. "My entrepreneurial instincts got the better of me. I realised wine was an industry with a lot of potential," says Patil. It wasn't easy having to give up a secure job. And for wife Kiran, a marketing executive, it was tough to

give up a corporate lifestyle and go to a village. But a crucial tie-up with Italian wine consultants Enofly helped and he swiftly converted the family's fruit orchards into vineyards of Italian grape varieties. And Nashik's weather was perfect for viticulture.

Patil's marketing strategy was different. His wife and he made direct contact with retailers and toured restaurants with their wines. Though the entry of foreign players like Diageo and Seagrams is heating up the race, Patil is confident of his wines competing

in the big league. The couple is also exploring wine tourism with tours of the vineyards and a wine bar that is slated to open by the year end.

"There is a direct link between wine tourism and sales. People identify with the product and brand better," says Kiran. With a working capital of Rs 5 crore invested in his 32,000 sq ft stone-grey winery, overlooking a

200-acre vineyard—it may not remind one of the French

chateaus but boasts of state-of-the-art machinery—Patil is dreaming big and in the colour red.

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PER CENT IS THE
RISE IN PEOPLE
DRINKING WINE IN
INDIA FROM 2006

MANDAR DEODHAR

